

Registan Square

A monumental public square in the Uzbek city of Samarkand on the historic Silk Road

Six centuries ago, Registan Square was the center of commercial life in one of the world's wealthiest cities, Samarkand. The city had grown rich on account of its location on the Silk Road trade route between China and the West. In the 14th century, it had also become the capital of the empire created by the warrior Timur the Lame. It was Timur's grandson Ulugh Beg who, between 1417 and 1420, built the first of the three *madrasas*—Muslim schools—that now dominate the square. The Ulugh Beg *madrasa* developed into one of the most important centers of learning in the Islamic world. The other two were built in the 17th century, completing an architectural ensemble of breathtaking splendor.

A square of madrasas

The Ulugh Beg *madrasa*, and the Sher-Dor *madrasa* built to mirror it on the opposite side of the square, have vast portals flanked by free-standing minarets. The Tilya-Kori *madrasa* has a lower facade with minarets attached. Behind each of the portals were lecture halls, student dormitories, and a mosque. Samarkand is now one of the major tourist attractions of Uzbekistan.



△ TILYA-KORI MADRASA

The two minarets of Tilya-Kori *madrasa* are capped with turquoise glazed domes, matching the main dome that dominates the building. Completed in 1660, Tilya-Kori was the last of the three *madrasas* built on Registan Square.



△ GLAZED SPLENDOR

The facade of the 17th-century Sher-Dor *madrasa* is magnificently decorated with glazed tiles and bricks. Its mosaics of tigers pursuing deer breach the Muslim custom prohibiting representation of living creatures.



△ FLORAL CEILING

The interior of the Shah Mosque is lined with mosaics of hand-painted seven-color tiles. The technique of coloring tiles in several colors was perfected in Safavid Iran.



△ ELABORATE DECORATION

"Stalactite" tilework is a distinctive feature of Iranian Islamic architecture. This fine example embellishes the main entrance to the Shah Mosque.